

Area of Study 2A – Catholic Christianity

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Catholic Christianity as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of peace and conflict, and crime and punishment.

There are four sections: Catholic Beliefs, Crime and Punishment, Living the Catholic Life and Peace and Conflict.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Catholics today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how the Bible informs a Catholic's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Catholic Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Catholic Christianity with wider Christian perspectives as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.2)*

Students should recognise that Catholic Christianity is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Catholic Christianity with wider Christian perspectives and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Catholic Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within the wider Christian tradition in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout including reference to Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually: God as the Father, Son and Holy Spirit; how this is reflected in worship and belief in the life of a Catholic today.
1.2	Biblical understandings of God as a Trinity of Persons: the nature and significance of God as a Trinity of Persons, including reference to the baptism of Jesus (Matthew 3:13–17); the historical development of the doctrine of the Trinity, including reference to the First Council of Nicaea and the First Council of Constantinople.
1.3	Creation: the nature and significance of the biblical account of Creation, including Genesis 1–3; and how it may be understood in divergent ways in Christianity, including reference to literal and metaphorical interpretations; the significance of the Creation account for Catholics in understanding the nature and characteristics of God, especially as Creator, benevolent, omnipotent and eternal.
1.4	The significance of the Creation account in understanding the nature of humanity: the nature and significance of the nature of humanity being created in the image of God, including reference to Genesis 1–3 and divergent understandings of humanity’s relationship with Creation (dominion and stewardship); the implications of these beliefs for Catholics today.
1.5	The Incarnation: Jesus as incarnate Son, the divine Word, both fully God and fully human; the scriptural origins of this belief, including John 1:1–18 and its importance for Catholics today.
1.6	The events in the Paschal Mystery: Catholic teachings about the life, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus, including reference to Luke 24; the redemptive efficacy of these events and their significance for Catholics today.
1.7	The significance of the life, death, resurrection and ascension of Jesus for Catholic beliefs about salvation and grace, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the implications and significance of these events for Catholic practice today.
1.8*	Catholic beliefs about eschatology: life after death; the nature of resurrection, judgement, heaven, hell and purgatory, including reference to John 11:17–27 and 2 Corinthians 5:1–10; divergent Christian beliefs about life after death, with reference to purgatory and the nature of resurrection; why belief in life after death is important for Catholics today.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Catholic attitudes towards justice: the nature of justice and why justice is important for Catholics, including Micah 3:1–12; Catholic teachings and responses to why justice is important for victims; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why justice is important, regardless of religion and belief, and Catholic responses to these attitudes.
2.2	Catholic attitudes towards crime: Catholic teachings about and responses to the nature, causes and problem of crime, including John 8:1–11; what action is taken by Christian individuals and Christian groups to end crime, including Prison Fellowship.
2.3	Catholic teachings about good, evil and suffering: Catholic teachings about the nature of good actions and how they are rewarded, and teachings about the nature of evil actions; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why people suffer, including believing in religion, and Catholic responses to them; divergent Christian understandings of why people suffer, including the Parable of the Sheep and Goats (Matthew 25:31–46).
2.4	Catholic attitudes towards punishment: the nature of punishment; why punishment is important for Catholics; the nature and meaning of biblical teachings about punishment, including Luke 12:35–48; Catholic teachings on why punishment can be regarded as justice and why punishment might be needed in society.
2.5	Catholic attitudes towards the aims of punishment: Catholic attitudes towards each of the aims of punishment (protection, retribution, deterrence and reformation); the nature and meaning of biblical examples of teaching about punishment, including Galatians 6:1–10.
2.6	Catholic teachings about forgiveness: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature of forgiveness and biblical teachings about it; how offenders are forgiven by the community and why this is needed; Catholic teachings about mercy and why is it important to show mercy to criminals, including Matthew 5:21–26.
2.7	Catholic teachings about the treatment of criminals: Catholic teachings about the treatment of criminals, including Proverbs 31:8–9; Catholic teachings about the use of torture, human rights, fair trial and trial by jury; divergent attitudes, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, towards the treatment of criminals, which may accept the use of torture if it is for the greater good.
2.8	Catholic attitudes towards the death penalty: the nature and purpose of capital punishment, Catholic teaching about capital punishment, divergent Christian teachings for and against capital punishment, including interpretations of Genesis 9:6, Exodus 21:8–13 and Matthew 5:38–48; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards the use of capital punishment, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, and Catholic responses to them.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	The sacramental nature of reality: Catholic teachings about how the whole of creation manifests the presence of God; the meaning and effects of each of the seven sacraments, including Catechism of the Catholic Church 1210–1211; the practice and symbolism of each sacrament; how sacraments communicate the grace of God; divergent Christian attitudes to sacraments, including reference to Orthodox and Protestant Christianity.
3.2*	Liturgical worship within Catholic Christianity: the nature and significance of the Mass for Catholics, including its structure and the Eucharist as the 'source and summit of Christian life', with reference to Lumen Gentium paragraph 7; divergent Christian attitudes towards the practice and meaning of liturgical worship, including its significance for Catholics and the less structured worship in evangelical Christian denominations.
3.3	The funeral rite as a liturgical celebration of the Church: practices associated with the funeral rite in the home, the church and the cemetery, including reference to 'Preparing my funeral' by Vincent Nichols, Archbishop of Westminster; the aims of the funeral rite, including communion with the deceased; the communion of the community and the proclamation of eternal life to the community and its significance for Catholics.
3.4	Prayer as the 'raising of hearts and minds to God': the nature and significance of different types of prayer; the Lord's Prayer, including Matthew 6:5–14, set (formulaic) prayers and informal (extempore) prayer; when each type might be used and why; the importance of prayer and the importance for Catholics of having different types of worship.
3.5	The role and importance of forms of popular piety: the nature and significance of the Rosary, Eucharistic adoration and Stations of the Cross; how each of these might be used and why; the importance of having different types of worship for Catholics, including reference to Catechism of the Catholic Church 1674–1676; divergent Christian attitudes to these forms of piety.
3.6	Pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of Catholic pilgrimage; the significance of the places people go on pilgrimage; divergent Christian understandings about whether pilgrimage is important for Christians today, with specific reference to Jerusalem, Lourdes, Rome, Walsingham and the Catechism of the Catholic Church 2691–2696.
3.7	Catholic Social Teaching: how Catholic Social Teaching reflects the teaching to show love of neighbour; Catholic teaching on justice, peace and reconciliation, Evangelii Gaudium paragraphs 182–237 – The inclusion of the poor in society; how these teachings might be reflected in the lives of individual Catholics, including reference to Matthew 25:31–46 (the Parable of the Sheep and Goats); the work of CAFOD, what it does and why.
3.8	Catholic mission and evangelism: the history and significance of mission and evangelism for Catholics; divergent ways this is put into practice by the Church and individual Catholics locally, nationally and globally, and how this fulfils the commission of Jesus and teachings of the Church, including Evangelii Gaudium Chapter 5.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Catholic attitudes towards peace: the nature and importance of peace for Catholics; Church teachings about peace; Jesus as a peacemaker, including interpretations of Luke 22:47–53 and as the 'Prince of Peace' Isaiah 9:6.
4.2	The role of Catholics in peacemaking: Church teachings about the role of Catholics today as peacemakers; the importance of justice, forgiveness and reconciliation for Catholics in peacemaking; the work of one Catholic group working for peace today, what it does and why it tries to work for peace, including interpretations of Matthew 5:1–16.
4.3	Catholic attitudes to conflict: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature and causes of conflict; Catholic responses to the problems conflict causes, including Matthew 26:47–56 and links to situation ethics; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes about the role of religion in the causes of conflict and Catholic responses to them.
4.4	Catholic attitudes to pacifism: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature and history of pacifism; Catholic teachings about passive resistance, including John 14:22–31 and an example of its use, including Thomas Merton; divergent Christian attitudes to pacifism, including reference to Quakers and passive resistance and Catholic responses to them.
4.5	Catholic attitudes to the Just War theory: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature, history and importance of the Just War theory; the conditions of a Just War; divergent Christian opinions about whether a Just War is possible with links to situation ethics; Catholic teachings on Just War, including interpretations of Romans 13:1–7; the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics.
4.6	Catholic attitudes to Holy War: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature of a Holy War; the nature and meaning of Catholic teachings about war and peace, including interpretations of Matthew 10:34–40; divergent Christian teachings about war; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards Holy War and Catholic responses to them.
4.7	Catholic attitudes to weapons of mass destruction (WMD): Catholic teachings and responses to the problems and benefits of WMD; Catholic attitudes towards the use of such weapons, including interpretations of Deuteronomy 20; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) and the application of ethical theories (such as utilitarianism) which support the acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, and Catholic responses to them.
4.8	Catholic attitudes to issues surrounding conflict: Catholic teachings and responses to the nature and history of problems involved in conflict – violence, war and terrorism, including Luke 6:27–31; how Catholics, including Dorothy Day and Oscar Romero, have worked to overcome these issues.